Conditional sub-patterns also allow named and relative capture groups, as well as lookaround assertions. The various syntaxes are given below:

Table 8-34. *PCRE conditional sub-patterns*

`(?(name)THEN|ELSE)`
`(?(<name>)THEN|ELSE)`
`(?('name')THEN|ELSE)`
	Named capture groups

`(?(-1)THEN|ELSE)`	Relative capture groups
`(?(?=PATTERN)THEN|ELSE)`	Positive lookahead
`(?(?!PATTERN)THEN|ELSE)`	Negative lookahead
`(?(?<=PATTERN)THEN|ELSE)`	Positive lookbehind
`(?(?<!PATTERN)THEN|ELSE)`	Negative lookbehind

Recursive

Recursive sub-patterns (not universally supported by all regex engines, but PHP will handle them) have the special syntax `(?R)` that simply means "repeat the expression so far." Here comes the tricky part though: the pattern is repeated up to the recursion marker as many times as the engine can match; each time this happens we add a level of recursion that, if we allow the recursion to match zero times with a ? quantifier, is then unwound – matching the remainder of the expression recursively. This should make more sense with an example:

```
$text = 'aaabbb';
preg_match_all('/a(?R)?b/', $text, $matches);
print_r($matches[0]);
```

```
Output:
Array
(
    [0] => aaabbb
)
```